sat astride a Bengal tiger while she traveled on Earth. Today, there is a very real possibility that the Royal Bengal tiger could be lost altogether, remaining only in artworks and Indian postage stamps.

Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, the first female to govern India since Razia Sultana of the Delhi Sultanate, made a government mandate to save her nation's tigers. In 1973, she enacted Project Tiger as a means to protect the country's newly elected National Animal from extinction and murder at the hands of hunters. Multiple conservation efforts have been put in place to save the tiger, including the establishment of more than 50 tiger preserves, but it has proved very difficult to positively impact the Bengal's population. The Sariska Tiger Reserve in Rajasthan declared that it lost every one of its 16 protected tigers in 2005, a loss due mostly to poaching. In addition to the tiger's coat, the Bengal's teeth and bones are considered vital ingredients for Chinese medicines, which makes the cat exceptionally valuable to poachers. Project Tiger has been a challenge, but as the world's most tiger-rich country, India has managed to increase its wild tiger count by about 30 percent.

The government and people of India have worked hard to move from a culture of big game hunting to species preservationists, particularly with the rare animals who struggle the most to deal with growing human populations. India's over 500 wildlife sanctuaries help the nation care for its wildlife and also boost the country's tourism. Tourists and Indians alike have shown great interest in—and empathy for—the big cats of the subcontinent, who can rarely be seen in other parts of the world. The endangered snow leopards of the Himalayas are just one of the stunning species of big cats to call India home. It's large paws, long fur, and black, gray, and white spotted pattern sets it apart from its larger tiger and lion cousins of the forests. Several of these beautiful panthers can be found in Hemis National Park in Kashmir and Jammu.

Preservation has taken over the whole of India, with nearly every creature finding niche refuge in at least one park or facility. One-horned rhinoceros frolic at the Kaziranga National Park in Assam, Kashmir stags find refuge at Dachigam, and the Asiatic lions proudly guard their prides in Gujarat's Gir Forest National Park. Pre-history and the early Modern Age may have been tough on India's precious animals, but the people are working hard to shelter and care for the species that also call India home.